

Great Indian Dope Trick

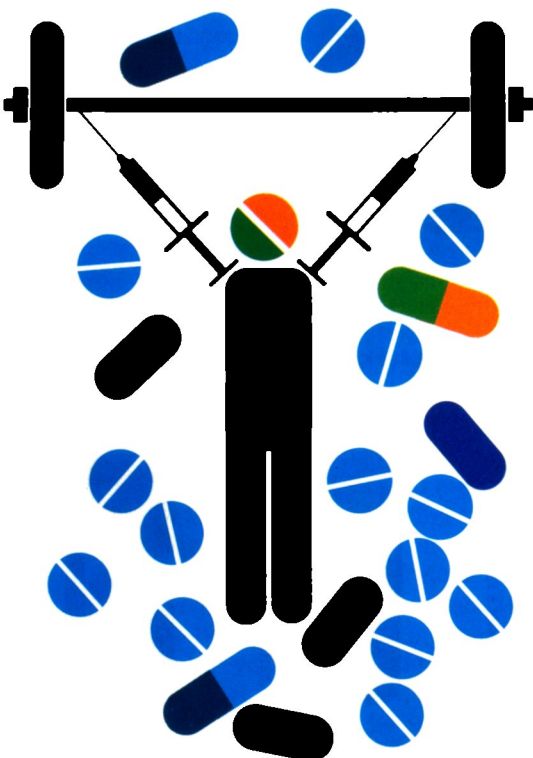


Message to the heavies of the International Weightlifting Federation (IWF): please ban India. For as long as you like. The drug-taking lifters and officials who pushed them with promises of medals, jobs, rewards. Ban them as severely as possible. So that those who follow understand that doping is a shortcut to sporting suicide.

The IWF will take more than a few weeks to arrive at a decision about the six Indian lifters who tested positive in out-of-competition testing held in September. The ban could be as long as two years and should there be three or more lifters, the national body gets banned too. India has had more than two strikes already by that count and is sweating even more now because a two-year ban would keep Indian weightlifters out of Delhi's 2010 Commonwealth Games.

Well, boo-hoo. Indian weightlifting shouldn't even be there—or at other major events. Each of our sports federations competes in the bad management and corrupt official category and even though hockey tries hard, it is weightlifting that wins gold. The IWF has just resigned en masse saying they had "decided to take moral responsibility". In truth, those gentlemen would not recognise moral responsibility if it sidled over and slapped them in the face.

The outbreak of "moral responsibility" came due to some arm-twisting by the sports ministry and the Indian Olympic Association. Next week, an election notice will be out to vote in a new national body without the previous crooks. Even then, the honest may not inherit that patch of earth. Only familiar shape-shifters will.



SAURABH SINGH/www.indiatodayimages.com

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Indian weightlifting cannot be surprised that the IWF is beating down its door. Last year, IWF expert Maged Salama sent to help the Indians clean up their dirty laundry left six months into his job. Indian weightlifting, he said, had a system that encouraged "systematic doping" for its lifters. His moves to change the training programme was blocked by the national federation (the moral responsibility police) which made him leave. Rather than support Salama and use the ministry's muscle, the Sports Authority of India was involved in a financial dispute instead. They allowed him to go and let Indian sport's druglords continue to rule.

The ban may eventually be back-dated and merely a year-long. So that our lifters can be seen at the 2010 Commonwealth Games. They may even win a bunch of medals. Those medals may even boost our tally. But please remember, they will not be clean.

SIGNPOSTS

DIED: Former Union minister and Congress leader **B. Shankaranand**, 85, who led the Parliamentary panel probing the kickbacks in the Bofors case.

COMMISSIONED: Sub Lieutenants **Seema Rani Sharma** and **Ambica Hooda** as navigators in the flying branch of the Indian Navy. They will be the first



women combatants in the armed forces.

DIED: Journalist **Naresh Chandra Rajkhowa**, who broke the story about the Dalai Lama's escape from Tibet through Tawang in 1959 and his seeking asylum in India. Rajkhowa was the first Indian journalist to have interviewed the Dalai Lama. He was 85.

APPOINTED: Governor of Tripura **Dr (Mrs) Kamla Beniwal**, as the next governor of Gujarat. She will be the first woman governor of the state in 30 years after Sharda Mukerjee (1978-83).